UNIVERSITY OF THE PEOPLE

HIST 1421-01 - AY2027-T1

Assignment Unit 4

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Date: September 24, 2026

The Republic We Inherited, the Republic We Lost

A Letter from a Roman Senator, 44 BCE

To my son Marcus,

I write this letter while Rome is still trembling from the death of Gaius Julius Caesar. Only days ago, his blood covered the floor of the Senate, and men who called themselves defenders of liberty struck down the most powerful man in Rome. I should feel relieved. Instead, I feel afraid. I have begun to wonder whether we killed a man who threatened the Republic or merely exposed how weak the Republic had already become.

Our ancestors taught us to value *mos maiorum*, the way of the ancestors. We were expected to honor tradition, respect the laws, serve the Republic, and place duty above private ambition. A Roman citizen was supposed to possess *virtus*, not simply courage in battle, but the character required to serve the community. *Pietas* demanded

loyalty to family, the gods, and Rome itself. Yet I now fear that many of our leaders have learned to speak about these virtues while pursuing power for themselves.

I remember how the struggle between patricians and plebeians once forced Rome to change. The creation of the Tribune of the Plebs gave ordinary citizens a means of resisting abuse by powerful magistrates. The Twelve Tables made laws more visible and accessible, while the assemblies allowed citizens to participate in public decisions. The Senate remained powerful, but the Republic was not supposed to belong to one man. Its strength came from the balance among institutions, traditions, and civic responsibilities (Berger et al., 2016; Brooks, 2024).

But our success created problems that our ancestors could not have imagined. Rome conquered territories across the Mediterranean, yet victory brought wealth and enslaved labor that transformed Roman society. Many small farmers struggled while wealthy landowners expanded their estates. Soldiers spent years away from their farms, and many returned to economic hardship. Rome filled with landless citizens who depended increasingly on political leaders rather than the older networks of independent farmers and patrons (Berger et al., 2016).

Then came Gracchi. Tiberius Gracchus attempted to redistribute public land to poorer citizens, believing that Rome needed independent farmers for both its social stability and military strength. His political opponents killed him in 133 BCE. His brother Gaius later pursued further reforms, including grain and public works measures, but he too died violently. Whatever one thinks of their methods, their deaths showed something terrifying: disagreement within the Republic was becoming a struggle in which political opponents could be treated as enemies rather than fellow citizens (Brooks, 2024).

Sulla made the danger even clearer. He marched into his army against Rome, something that should have been unthinkable. His actions demonstrated that a general could place personal loyalty from soldiers above loyalty to the Republic. Later, Marius and other commanders contributed to a political culture in which military power became increasingly connected to individual leaders. Once Roman armies became instruments of political ambition, the laws of the Republic were no longer strong enough to restrain every commander (Berger et al., 2016).

And now we have a Caesar.

Some Romans admired him because he brought military victories, political reforms, and enormous popularity. Others feared that his accumulation of authority destroyed the balance of the Republic. His assassination was therefore presented as an act of liberty. Yet what troubles me is that the men who killed him did not restore the trust that once held our institutions together. They used violence to defend a political order that had already been weakened by violence.

Cicero reminds us that virtue must be practiced through public duty and justice, not merely praised in speeches (Cicero, 1913). That lesson feels painfully relevant. If *virtus* becomes only a word used to justify ambition, and if *pietas* means loyalty only to one's faction, then we have emptied Roman values of their meaning.

Has Rome lost its soul, or is this transformation inevitable because Rome has grown too large for the Republic we inherited? I do not know. Perhaps expansion itself was not the true enemy. Rome had changed, but our political habits did not change quickly enough. The institutions created for a city-state were struggling to govern a Mediterranean power filled with enormous wealth, competing elites, large armies, and deep social divisions.

Tonight, I will return to the Senate. I will speak for the laws even if the men around me no longer agree on what those laws should mean. I cannot promise that the Republic will survive. But I can still choose to act as a citizen rather than as a factional weapon. Perhaps that is the last duty left to us.

If Rome is to survive, it will not be because another powerful man saves us. It will be because Romans once again understand that power without duty destroys the very community that gives power its meaning.

Postscript: A Reflection on My Own Time

Roman experience also raises a question that remains meaningful today: what happens when the pursuit of power becomes more important than the principles that are supposed to guide public life? Modern societies have constitutions, courts, legislatures, elections, and other institutions designed to limit authority and protect citizens. Yet institutions depend not only on written rules but also on people’s willingness to respect them.

The Roman Republic reminds us that political systems can become vulnerable when wealth, personal ambition, social inequality, and loyalty to individuals become stronger than loyalty to shared rules. At the same time, Rome shows that political institutions can evolve when citizens demand greater protection and participation. The Roman Tribune, the assemblies, and the written laws all developed partly because earlier arrangements had failed to address social conflict.

For me, the central lesson is not that change is dangerous or that tradition should never be questioned. It is that reform, authority, and civic freedom require responsibility. A society may preserve impressive institutions on paper while weakening them through repeated violations of their underlying principles. The challenge is to ensure that power remains connected to justice, duty, and responsibility rather than becoming an end in itself.

References

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